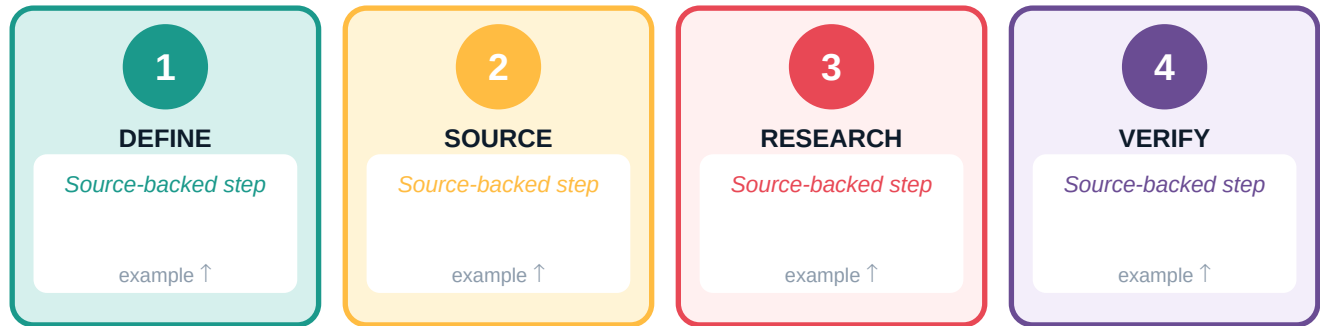


CHAPTER 13

Tools, What AI Can Do Beyond Text



A I I S N O T J U S T A T E X T G E N E R A T O R The AI tools available in late 2026 can do considerably more than generate text. Understanding which capabilities exist, and which don't, determines what you can ask for, what you need to verify externally, and where AI can genuinely replace tasks that previously required separate tools.

This chapter introduces the main tool categories. Because capabilities vary by platform, by plan level, and change frequently, all specific capabilities include a Product Note with a volatility rating. High-volatility items are not in the main body.

B E Y O N D T E X T Web search Research Current information Multi-source reports Check: Check sources and dates Check: Inspect citations

Code execution Files and images Calculations and data Source material and visual input Check: Check formulas and inputs Check: Confirm what was actually read

W E B S E A R C H Most major AI platforms can search the web during a conversation. This changes one of AI's most significant limitations: its knowledge cutoff.

Without web search, AI's knowledge has a cutoff date. If you ask about recent events, current prices, or the latest data, AI either doesn't know or (more dangerously) generates plausible- sounding but outdated information.

With web search enabled, AI can retrieve current information and incorporate it into responses. It can check whether something has changed, find recent statistics, and access information published after its training cutoff.

WHAT WEB SEARCH CHANGES: AI can answer questions about recent events AI can retrieve current data rather than estimating from outdated training data AI can find specific sources rather than

relying on memory

WHAT WEB SEARCH DOES NOT CHANGE: AI still interprets and summarises what it finds, and can still get that interpretation wrong. Not all information is publicly accessible on the web. AI can still be wrong about which sources to trust. You still need to verify important claims.

PRODUCT NOTE (VERIFIED SEPTEMBER 2026): OpenAI, Anthropic, and Google all document web-search or research capabilities, but access, names, limits, and default behaviour vary by product, plan, region, and rollout. Always confirm whether search was used in a given response if accuracy matters.

Volatility: MEDIUM

DEEP RESEARCH AND MULTI-STEP WEB RESEARCH Some platforms now offer a research mode that does more than answer a single search question. It can plan a search, investigate several sources, compare what it finds, and return a cited report. The name and exact behaviour vary: a platform may call it Deep Research, Research, or use another label.



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Use it when the question is broad, current, and worth the time required for a proper investigation. Do not use it as a shortcut around verification.

A RELIABLE RESEARCH BRIEF 1. State the decision or piece of work the research will support. 2. Define the date range, geography, audience, and terms that matter. 3. Ask for primary or authoritative sources where they exist. 4. Request a source-linked report that separates evidence from interpretation. 5. Review the plan or scope before the research runs, if the platform offers that option. 6. Open the important sources and verify the claims you intend to use.

WEB RESEARCH CHECKLIST Did I define the date, place, audience, and decision this research supports? Did the tool actually use web sources, or did it answer from its existing context? Can I open the cited source and find the claim there? Is the source primary or authoritative for this question? Did the tool distinguish evidence from interpretation? What remains uncertain, disputed, or outside the scope of the search?

For example:

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Research the current rules for [specific question] in [jurisdiction] as of [date]. This will support [decision or document]. Prefer official government, regulator, company, or primary research sources. Give me: 1. the answer in plain English; 2. the sources for each important claim; 3. areas where sources disagree or the position is uncertain; 4. a list of facts I should verify before relying on the result. Do not fill gaps with assumptions. Say what you could not establish.

The citations are a map back to the evidence, not a guarantee that the report is correct. Research tools can select weak sources, misread a source, or draw a conclusion the source does not support. The verification step remains yours.

PRODUCT NOTE OpenAI, Google, and Anthropic all document research tools that can search across multiple sources and return citations, but access, limits, connected sources, and names vary by plan, region, and product. Check the current help centre before designing a workflow around one. The stable principle is: define the research task, inspect the sources, and verify the claims that matter.

Volatility: HIGH

CODE EXECUTION AND CALCULATION Some AI platforms can write and run code within the conversation, enabling reliable calculation and data processing.

This is significant because it addresses one of AI's consistent weaknesses: arithmetic and calculation. When AI uses code execution, it doesn't estimate calculations, it runs them. The result is accurate in the same way a spreadsheet result is accurate (if the formula is right).

Practical uses:



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Accurate calculations on data you provide Processing and analysing datasets Running formulas or statistical operations Generating charts and graphs from data

What this changes: Calculations performed via code execution are reliable. Calculations performed without code execution, AI simply generating the answer as text, are not reliably accurate, particularly for anything beyond simple arithmetic.

The rule: If your task involves maths that matters, either use a platform with code execution enabled, or verify the calculation yourself.

PRODUCT NOTE (VERIFIED SEPTEMBER 2026): Several major platforms support code execution, file analysis, or both, but the feature name, access, limits, and supported formats vary. Consult the current platform documentation before relying on a calculation or data workflow.

Volatility: MEDIUM

IMAGE GENERATION Some AI tools can generate images from text descriptions. This capability is useful for:

Rough concept visualisations for design briefs Placeholder images for presentations Illustrations for non-commercial documents Visual brainstorming

WHAT TO BE CAREFUL OF: Generated images may not be suitable for commercial use without checking the platform's terms

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Generated images of people can produce photorealistic results that may be misleading out of context
Quality varies significantly across platforms

PRODUCT NOTE (VERIFIED SEPTEMBER 2026): Image generation is integrated into several major AI platforms, but product names, models, access, and licensing terms vary. Verify the platform's current terms and applicable law before using generated images commercially.

Volatility: HIGH, See Appendix E for current details.

FILE CREATION AND EXPORT AI tools increasingly support creating downloadable files: documents, spreadsheets, presentations. This is still an evolving area, with quality and reliability varying considerably.

The practical approach: use AI to generate the content and structure, then create the final formatted document in your standard tool (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Google Workspace). Attempting to produce final, formatted output directly from AI is often slower and less reliable than the two-step approach.

WHAT AI TOOLS CANNOT RELIABLY DO (AS OF LATE 2026) Equally important is knowing what AI tools currently cannot do well:

Send communications on your behalf without explicit confirmation steps
Access your internal systems (email, calendar, CRM, databases) without integration tools set up by your organisation
Make decisions that require judgment, ethics, or accountability, AI can analyse and recommend; decisions remain with you



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Replace professional advice in law, medicine, finance, or other regulated domains, AI can inform; professionals advise

WATCH OUT TOOL AVAILABILITY CHANGES. A CAPABILITY THAT EXISTS TODAY MAY BE MODIFIED, RESTRICTED, OR REMOVED

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